Boston University Questrom Degree Programs

Gutenberg Update | *September 2020 - present (in progress)*

Links:

- Design Presentation
- Code Samples: Custom Blocks, Variations, and Block Template
- Live Link - MSBA Update
- YouTube tutorial playlist I published based on this project to share knowledge

This project demonstrates my ability to:

- Design components for block-based editors such as Gutenberg within an existing design system
- Communicate intended functionality and connect design ideas to functionality in a Gutenberg-forward mindset
- Identify what is and isn't possible within the constraints of Gutenberg, and design goal-oriented solutions accordingly
- Build custom Gutenberg blocks in JavaScript which leverage existing Gutenberg components, as well as experimental components and functions

Key Responsibilities

- Take a client-provided wireframe, **extract functionality requirements and desires**, and suggest a general **WordPress-based development direction** based on those needs - in this case, Gutenberg
- Create **component-based designs** and connect existing **brand guidelines** and theme design to **Gutenberg blocks**
- Recommend **custom blocks** to achieve content goals
- Clearly **explain the benefits and limitations of Gutenberg** blocks, and how launching the new functionality will work

Challenges & Responses

Challenges

- One of the first custom themes at Boston University to **leverage and build custom Gutenberg blocks** without the initial help of an external team
- Both the **existing design** for the degree programs post type and the **new design** had to be usable on the live site **simultaneously** to allow editors to launch content
- Boston University still hasn't updated WordPress training to include how to use Gutenberg, so the success of this project after handoff relied on **clear and intuitive user interface patterns**

Responses

- I took time to familiarize myself with Gutenberg before proposing this direction by experimenting with the block editor, and recreated the wireframe using Gutenberg blocks to discover possible limitations.
- At the beginning of development, I familiarized myself with the WordPress create-block package, and created a template for other designers to start from and modify.
- I worked with the development team to ensure the new Gutenberg functionality only appeared on degree program posts with Gutenberg enabled, and to test that all functionality worked with the classic editor plugin so the client could migrate content to the new editor at their pace.
- I leveraged block variations to create groups of blocks with specific content purposes and placeholder instructions, and used the code editor view to identify what properties I could set using variations to reduce the amount of documentation I had to write to show the client how to create the ideal content.